

Shopping & Money

Sweden is one of the most cashless countries on earth. If you show up with only euros or dollars, you'll have a problem. This chapter covers how money works, how to shop, and the words you need.

The Cashless Reality

Sweden runs on cards and Swish (a mobile payment app). Many shops, restaurants, market stalls, and even some churches don't accept cash at all. You'll see signs everywhere saying 'Kontantfritt' (cash-free). This isn't a trend — it's the norm.

Tar ni kort?

/tar nee kort/

Do you take card? — The answer is almost always yes.

Kan jag betala med kort?

/kan yah beh-TAH-lah med kort/

Can I pay by card? — Same question, slightly more formal.

Kan jag betala med Swish?

/kan yah beh-TAH-lah med swish/

Can I pay with Swish? — Very common at markets and small businesses.

Kontaktlös betalning

/kon-TAKT-luhs beh-TAHL-ning/

Contactless payment — Tap your card or phone. Works everywhere.

Kvitto, tack

/KVIT-oh, tahk/

Receipt, please.

Kontantfritt

/kon-TAHNT-frit/

Cash-free — A sign you'll see on doors and at registers.

Var kan jag växla pengar?

/var kan yah VEK-slah PENG-ar/

Where can I exchange money? — Look for 'Forex' or 'X-change' offices.

CULTURE TIP

Get a travel card with no foreign transaction fees before coming to Sweden. Wise, Revolut, or a similar multi-currency card is perfect. Swish requires a Swedish bank account and personnummer (personal ID number), so tourists can't use it. Don't worry — card works everywhere Swish does.

Understanding Swedish Kronor

The currency is Swedish krona (SEK), plural kronor. There are coins (1, 2, 5, 10 kr) and bills (20, 50, 100, 200, 500, 1000 kr) — but you'll rarely see either since everything is digital. Roughly: 10 SEK ≈ 1 EUR ≈ 1 USD (but always check the current rate).

Hur mycket kostar det?

/hoor MY-keh KOS-tar deh/

How much does it cost? — You learned this in Chapter 2. Here it becomes essential.

Det kostar hundra kronor

/deh KOS-tar H00N-drah KR00-nor/

It costs one hundred kronor.

Kronor / Kr / SEK

/KR00-nor/

Kronor — You'll see it written as 'kr' or 'SEK' on price tags.

Spänn

/spen/

Bucks / quid — Slang for kronor. 'Det kostar femtio spann' = 'It costs 50 bucks.'

Dyrt / Billigt

/dyhrt / BIL-igt/

Expensive / Cheap — Sweden is generally expensive. You'll use 'dyrt' a lot.

CULTURE TIP

Sweden IS expensive. A coffee costs 45-65 SEK, a beer at a bar 75-100 SEK, a restaurant main course 150-250 SEK, and a basic lunch 120-160 SEK. Budget tip: always go for 'Dagens Lunch' (Chapter 3) — best value meal in the country. Supermarket cooking saves a fortune too.

Shopping Phrases

Whether you're at H&M; on its home turf, a vintage shop in Södermalm, or a design store in Gothenburg — these phrases cover everything you need.

Jag bara tittar

/yah BAH-rah TIT-ar/

I'm just looking — The universal 'leave me alone politely' phrase.

Har ni det här i en annan storlek?

/har nee deh hair ee en AH-nan ST00R-lek/

Do you have this in another size?

Har ni en mindre / större?

/har nee en MIN-dreh / STUH-reh/

Do you have a smaller / bigger one?

Var är provrummet?

/var air PROOV-ruh-met/

Where is the fitting room?

Passar det?

/PAS-ar deh/

Does it fit? — A shop assistant might ask you this.

Det passar perfekt

/deh PAS-ar per-FEKT/

It fits perfectly.

Det är för stort / litet

/deh air fur stoort / LEE-tet/

It's too big / small.

Jag tar den

/yah tar den/

I'll take it.

Rea / Extrapris

/REH-ah / EX-trah-prees/

Sale / Special price — Rea season is January and July. Swedes go hard.

CULTURE TIP

Swedish rea (sale) season happens twice a year: after Christmas (January) and after Midsummer (late June/July). Discounts can be massive — 50-70% off. If you're visiting during these times, you'll see 'Rea' signs everywhere.

Mellandagsrea (between-Christmas-days-sale, Dec 27+) is when the real chaos begins.

Returns & Problems

Sweden has strong consumer protection. You generally have 14-30 days to return items with a receipt. Online purchases have a 14-day cooling off period by law (ångerrätt).

Kan jag lämna tillbaka det här?

/kan yah LEM-nah til-BAH-kah deh hair/

Can I return this?

Jag har kvittot här

/yah har KVIT-oh-t hair/

I have the receipt here.

Den är trasig

/den air TRAH-sig/

It's broken — Works for any defective item.

Kan jag byta den?

/kan yah BYH-tah den/

Can I exchange it?

Jag vill ha pengarna tillbaka

/yah vill hah PENG-ar-nah til-BAH-kah/

I want my money back.

Öppet köp

/UH-pet shuhp/

Open purchase / returnable — Look for this on receipts.

Sizes & Colors

Quick reference for clothes shopping. Swedish sizes follow European standards.

XS / S / M / L / XL

Same as international sizing

Extra small, Small, Medium, Large, Extra Large — Same abbreviations used.

Liten / Medium / Stor

/LEE-ten / MEH-dee-um / stoor/

Small / Medium / Large — For non-clothing items.

Svart / Vit

/svahrt / veet/

Black / White.

Blå / Röd / Gul / Grön

/bloh / ruhd / gool / gruhn/

Blue / Red / Yellow / Green — The Swedish flag colors are blue and yellow!

Grå / Brun / Rosa / Orange / Lila

/groh / broon / ROH-sah / oh-RANSH / LEE-lah/

Gray / Brown / Pink / Orange / Purple.

Vilken färg har ni?

/VIL-ken fairy har nee/

What colors do you have?

Swedish Shopping Culture

A few things about shopping in Sweden that might surprise you.

Pantamera

/PAN-tah-MEH-rah/

Recycle for money — Return bottles and cans at any supermarket for 1-2 SEK each.

Pant

/pahnt/

Deposit — The refundable deposit on bottles and cans.

Påse?

/POH-seh/

Bag? — The cashier will ask if you need a bag. Bring your own to save 7-8 SEK.

Självscanning

/SHELV-SKAH-ning/

Self-checkout / Self-scanning — Very common in Swedish supermarkets.

Medlemskort / Kundkort

/MED-lems-kort / KOOND-kort/

Membership card / Customer card — Many stores have loyalty programs.

CULTURE TIP

Pant (bottle deposit) is a big deal in Sweden. Almost all cans and plastic bottles have a deposit of 1-2 SEK. You return them at recycling machines in any supermarket and get a receipt to use as store credit or cash. It's so popular that some people collect bottles and cans from public bins — this is called 'panta'. Don't throw away your bottles — recycle them and get your money back!

CULTURE TIP

Stores in Sweden generally close earlier than you might expect. Most shops close at 18:00-19:00 on weekdays, 15:00-16:00 on Saturdays, and many are closed on Sundays (or open limited hours). Supermarkets stay open longer — some until 22:00-23:00. Plan accordingly.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Next up: Chapter 06 — Making Friends (or Trying To)

Swedes have a reputation for being hard to befriend. Here's how to crack the code.